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Wednesday July 15th, 2026

While many U.S. based companies have declared their commitment in reducing their carbon footprint, the roadmaps behind these voluntary pledges remain ambiguous. Eavis and Krauss (2021) present this idea in, "What's Really Behind Corporate Promises on Climate Change?" where the absence of mandatory, standardized disclosure make corporate climate pledges difficult to uphold voluntarily, demonstrated through their documented shortcomings. Using BlackRock's widely publicized net-zero "ambition" as its anchor example, the article argues that voluntary corporate climate action, however well marketed, can be an unreliable substitute for regulatory accountability.

Eavis and Krauss (2021) trace a pattern across several major U.S. firms, where public environmental pledges frequently omit the operational detail that would make them verifiable. Particularly, BlackRock's 2050 net-zero goals lacked specification regarding what share of its $8.7 trillion in assets under management would be zero-emission, providing further clarification after reporter pressure. Moreover, just over a third of S&P 500 companies had set targets that the Institutional Shareholder Services (ISS) considered ambitious, 215 had no target at all, and the remainder had weak targets, meaning roughly two-thirds of the index falls short of credible commitments, highlighting disparities surrounding climate action. However, Levi Strauss demonstrated that despite having intentions to reduce their carbon emissions within their supply-chain, those emissions reportedly rose 13 percent between 2016 and 2019, indicating the lack of consequences for corporations failing their publicly affirmed intentions. Likewise, Cargill's 2010 pledge to end deforestation-linked sourcing by 2020 was pushed back a full decade to 2030, further affirming the need for accountability. Alternatively, Google and Microsoft conceded that the technology needed for their "moonshot" goals, such as large-scale carbon removal, does not fully exist yet. As Microsoft's chief environmental officer Lucas Joppa notes, voluntary commitments are insufficient; binding standards are required for economy-wide net-zero progress.

Notably, the article's strength stems from the authors' use of concrete contrasts and external evaluations rather than broad accusations of greenwashing. By setting Walmart's vetted, supplier-inclusive targets against Costco's and Netflix's lack of any targets, and by drawing on independent assessments from Science Based Targets and ISS rather than corporate self-reporting, the piece grounds its claims in externally validated comparisons rather than corporate narratives. Spokespersons responses, such as Levi Strauss's sustainability officer disputing the 13-percent

figure adds balance by allowing readers to see how companies defend or reinterpret their own performance rather than admitting failure in adhering to their environmental goals. However, the main limitation lies in the documentation of vague, underperforming commitments without examining why companies tailor such phrasing. BlackRock's hedged language, "increasing the role of votes on shareholder proposals," for instance, is quoted without drawing out how it functions rhetorically, projecting engagement without specifying scope, timelines or measurable outcomes that is clear to readers. This avoids binding commitment, allowing the company to appear responsive while preserving maximum flexibility. A more critical reading would have named this pattern as the mechanism underlying every example, rather than exemplifying the shortfalls each company has regarding their climate pledges, showcasing why mandatory disclosure matters to eliminate protective ambiguity of such statements made by companies.

Furthermore, the article treats voluntary versus mandatory climate governance as a binary, closing on Joppa's call for "requirements and standards" without addressing how politically fragile any regulatory regime can be. The years since publication have made this concrete, exemplified by former U.S. president Biden's rejoining of the Paris Agreement. As cited early in the piece as federal momentum, current U.S. president Trump issued a withdrawal order in January 2025, leading to the country's exit from the Paris Agreement effective January 27, 2026, alongside a move to withdraw from the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) (Aeberhard et al., 2026). This political misalignment makes the article's own qualms more concrete as neither corporate pledges nor global treaties are self-enforcing, and both can be reversed once financial and political incentive changes, ultimately undercutting global efforts to reduce the impacts brought about by rapid climate change.

Google's own Environmental Report supplies evidence that sharpens this tension. In 2025, Google's electricity load grew 37 percent year-over-year as it scaled the data-center infrastructure needed for A.I. expansion (Google, 2026, p. 7). While operational emissions fell modestly, a larger increase in supply chain emissions meant that there was an overall increase in emissions driven largely by that same A.I. buildout (Google, 2026, p. 7). Although Google (2020) is publicly committed to running on carbon-free energy at all times by 2030, industry competitiveness is a legitimate constraint on what any one company can do unilaterally but can also function as cover where firms can cite competitive pressure to justify emissions-intensive expansion while still

marketing a net-zero goal that the expansion is undermining. Indeed, this ties back to the ideas Eavis and Krauss argue regarding accountability as Google can delay their sustainability goals if need be, without facing ramifications for overpromising and underdelivering.

Contrastingly, the report also documents genuine electrical efficiency engineering. Google reports fleet-wide power-usage effectiveness close to the theoretical ideal of 1.0, with 83 percent less overhead energy than the industry average, meaning that nearly every watt of electricity goes directly into running servers, with minimal energy lost to overhead (Google, 2026, p. 14). Although there was a net increase in A.I. buildout emissions, particularly due to their supply chain, Google (2026) also credits its A.I. driven insights in enabling roughly 41 million tonnes of CO_2-equivalent reduction in emissions through their tools like flood forecasting and efficient routing (p. 8). This complicates a reading of pure greenwashing where efficiency is improving sharply per unit of computing even as absolute emissions rise to maintain a competitive edge within the A.I. industry, a dynamic closer to a rebound effect than to empty promise-making. A company can be making authentic technical progress and still miss its own climate target when industry priorities shift, revealing a deeper challenge than the article's emphasis on vague pledges alone captures. Mandatory disclosure may curb rhetorical hedging, but it cannot fully address the rebound dynamics the article documents, where rising demand overwhelms even substantial engineering gains.

Overall, the article is a well-evidenced piece of accountability journalism. It depicts commitments varying enormously in rigor, S&P 500 companies lacking a credible target, and how committed companies routinely miss their own goals. Its weakness arguably resides within the gap between corporate language and performance without naming the rhetorical strategy that produces it and treats regulatory accountability as a stable fix without grappling with how reversible political commitments have proven to be. Google's report extends this point, where a company investing seriously in efficiency can still see total emissions rise once competitive A.I. pressure drives growth faster than efficiency can offset it. Hence, a stronger version of the article would center that dynamic by not only highlighting the vague language that weakens corporate accountability, but also by demonstrating where mandatory disclosure can create enforceable consequences to hold companies accountable.

References

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